Glimpses of his childhood in Kabul – the complaints to Humayun, the rapid turnover of tutors, the obsession with animals – suggest a kind of wilful energy, a mind too busy with its own delights to have time for duty. It was this very Akbar, however, who would grow into a man of remarkable intelligence, with a fine memory, endless curiosity and love of detail. These qualities must have existed in him, if in germinating form, when he was a boy; and it is entirely possible that Akbar was watching and learning, observing and absorbing far more than he let on.

What would such a boy do when a sudden load of responsibility fell upon him, when it was in his name that battles were fought and men were killed? In the second year of his reign, Akbar did what unhappy children often dream of doing: he ran away from home.

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The signs of stress had been showing. The only real order Akbar gave in his first year as padishah was to call for the harem. It was an ‘imperial command driven by great yearning’, writes Abul Fazl.[52] Bereaved, enthroned and overwhelmed, it is little wonder if Akbar was missing his mother. But the women were delayed; first, by Sulaiman’s siege of Kabul, ably defused by Munim Khan; then by Hemu’s challenge. It was only in the spring of 1557, a year after Akbar had called for them, that the harem arrived in Hindustan.

Akbar was camped outside Mankot, a little north of Multan, on the borders of Hindustan. Bairam Khan had resumed the campaign against Sikandar Suri, who was waging an increasingly hopeless resistance from within the Mankot fort, a grand and solid affair built on four hills by Salim Suri with the express purpose of repelling attacks from across the Indus.

After the horrors of Panipat, the Mughals seemed to be taking the siege as an opportunity for showmanship. On the very first day, Maham Anaka’s son, Adham Khan, had made a solo charge at a troop of soldiers from the fort – racing at them, sword in hand, slashing several to the ground ‘in dust and blood’ before making an about-turn and returning to ‘shouts of Bravo!’ Every day, writes Abul Fazl, ‘war-loving . . . men’ followed Adham Khan’s example and made such brash attacks.

It may have been Akbar who told Abul Fazl of these exploits; perhaps he